

0.0.1 The Noble Search (excerpt)

44. These five, O bhikkhus, are cords of sensual pleasure. Which five? Forms cognizable by the eye that are agreeable, lovely, pleasing, endearing, connected with sensual pleasures, provocative of lust. Sounds cognizable by the ear that are agreeable, lovely, pleasing, endearing, connected with sensual pleasures, provocative of lust. Aromas cognizable by the nose that are agreeable, lovely, pleasing, endearing, connected with sensual pleasures, provocative of lust. Flavors cognizable by the tongue that are agreeable, lovely, pleasing, endearing, connected with sensual pleasures, provocative of lust. Tangibles cognizable by the body that are agreeable, lovely, pleasing, endearing, connected with sensual pleasures, provocative of lust. These, O bhikkhus, are the five cords of sensual pleasure.

45. Indeed, O bhikkhus, those samanas or brahmanas who use these five cords of sensual pleasure bound, infatuated, committed, blind to their liability, not understanding the stepping out, those should be known thus: They have entered upon misfortune, entered upon a disaster, to be done by the Evil One as he pleases.

46. Just as, O bhikkhus, a forest deer might be lying trapped on a heap of snare. It should be known: "It has entered upon misfortune, entered upon a disaster, for the hunter to do with as he pleases. Now when the hunter

comes, it surely will not get away.” In just the same way, O bhikkhus, those samanas or brahmanas who use these five cords of sensual pleasure bound, infatuated, committed, blind to their liability, not understanding the stepping out, those should be known thus: They have entered upon misfortune, entered upon a disaster, to be done by the Evil One as he pleases.

47. But, O bhikkhus, those samanas or brahmanas who use these five cords of sensual pleasure not bound, not infatuated, not committed, seeing their liability, understanding the stepping out, those should be known thus: They have not entered upon misfortune, not entered upon a disaster, not to be done by the Evil One as he pleases.

48. Just as, O bhikkhus, a forest deer might be lying not trapped on a heap of snare. It should be known: “It has not entered upon misfortune, not entered upon a disaster, for the hunter cannot do with as he pleases. Now when the hunter comes, it will surely get away.” In just the same way, O bhikkhus, those samanas or brahmanas who use these five cords of sensual pleasure not bound, not infatuated, not committed, seeing their liability, understanding the stepping out, those should be known thus: They have not entered upon misfortune, not entered upon a disaster, not to be done by the Evil One as he pleases.

49. Just as, O bhikkhus, a forest deer living in the forest, a big forest, walks confidently, stands confidently, sits down confidently, lies down confidently. What is the reason for that? O bhikkhus, it has gone out of the reach of the hunter. In just the same way, O bhikkhus, quite secluded from sense-desires, secluded from unwholesome dhammas, a bhikkhu enters upon and abides in the happiness and pleasure born of seclusion connected with thinking and pondering, the first jhana. This, O bhikkhus, is said to be a bhikkhu who has blinded Mara. Having plucked out Mara's eyes, he has gone without a trace, not seen by the Evil One.

50. Furthermore, O bhikkhus, from the subsiding of thinking and pondering, with the internal tranquilization and unification of mind [due to] the absense of thinking and pondering, a bhikkhu enters upon and abides in the happiness and pleasure born of samadhi, the second jhana. This, O bhikkhus, is said to be a bhikkhu who has blinded Mara. Having plucked out Mara's eyes, he has gone without a trace, not seen by the Evil One.

51. Furthermore, O bhikkhus, with detachment from happiness, a bhikkhu dwelling mindful and contemplative, looks on with equanimity as he experiences pleasure in the body, of which the Noble Ones say: "He is a mindful one who [looks on with] equanimity, one who dwells in pleasure," enters upon and abides in the third jhana. This, O bhikkhus, is said to be a bhikkhu who has

blinded Mara. Having plucked out Mara's eyes, he has gone without a trace, not seen by the Evil One.

52. Furthermore, O bhikkhus, from the abandoning of [physical] pleasure and pain, from the extinction of former mental pleasure and mental pain, a bhikkhu enters upon and abides in the utter purity of mindfulness and equanimity without pain, without pleasure, the fourth jhana. This, O bhikkhus, is said to be a bhikkhu who has blinded Mara. Having plucked out Mara's eyes, he has gone without a trace, not seen by the Evil One.

53. Furthermore, O bhikkhus, from the complete surmounting of perceptions of form, from the extinguishing of perceptions of resistance, from non-attention to perceptions of diversity, "space is infinite," a bhikkhu enters upon and abides in the domain of infinite space. This, O bhikkhus, is said to be a bhikkhu who has blinded Mara. Having plucked out Mara's eyes, he has gone without a trace, not seen by the Evil One.

54. Furthermore, O bhikkhus, having completely surmounted the domain of infinite space, "consciousness is infinite," a bhikkhu enters upon and abides in the domain of infinite consciousness. This, O bhikkhus, is said to be a bhikkhu who has blinded Mara. Having plucked out Mara's eyes, he has gone without a trace, not seen by the Evil One.

55. Furthermore, O bhikkhus, having completely surmounted the domain of infinite consciousness, “there is nothing,” a bhikkhu enters upon and abides in the domain of nothingness. This, O bhikkhus, is said to be a bhikkhu who has blinded Mara. Having plucked out Mara’s eyes, he has gone without a trace, not seen by the Evil One.

56. Furthermore, O bhikkhus, having completely surmounted the domain of nothingness, a bhikkhu enters upon and abides in the domain of neither perception nor non-perception. This, O bhikkhus, is said to be a bhikkhu who has blinded Mara. Having plucked out Mara’s eyes, he has gone without a trace, not seen by the Evil One.

57. Furthermore, O bhikkhus, having completely surmounted the domain of neither perception nor non-perception, a bhikkhu enters upon and abides in the cessation of perception and feeling, and having seen with wisdom, his asavas come to be utterly extincted. This, O bhikkhus, is said to be a bhikkhu who has blinded Mara. Having plucked out Mara’s eyes, he has gone without a trace, not seen by the Evil One, having crossed over the adhesion in the world. He walks confidently, stands confidently, sits down confidently, lies down confidently. What is the reason for that? O bhikkhus, he has gone out of the reach of the Evil One.

58. This is what the Auspicious One said. Delighted, those bhikkhus rejoiced in the Auspicious One's words.